

Practice Paper 49 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Why the quiet feels strange

1 mark for understanding the **contrast** with the maternity ward; **1 mark** for explaining that the ward had been **constantly noisy** (crying, beeping, curtains being drawn) so the sudden silence is **unfamiliar and unsettling**.

Sample answer: The narrator has just spent five days in a hospital where there was **constant noise and activity**, so the **sudden silence** of her own flat feels **strange and unfamiliar**, almost making her uneasy.

Q2. [2] — “Afraid... as though the floorboards might startle her”

1 mark — She is **intensely anxious / nervous** about her newborn baby.

1 mark — She fears that **even the smallest, most ordinary disturbance** (a creaking floorboard) could wake or harm the baby — this shows her **heightened protectiveness** and the **fragility** of the new responsibility.

Q3. [2] — Daniel’s “wobbling” smile

1 mark — In the hospital his confidence had been steadier because **professionals were nearby** to take charge.

1 mark — At home, the smile **wobbles** because Daniel is now **nervous and uncertain**; he, too, feels the **weight of sole responsibility** for the baby. (Accept: he is masking fear to reassure her.)

Q4. [2] — “Rearranged at some invisible level”

1 mark — **Physically**, nothing in the room had moved.

1 mark — But **emotionally / in significance**, the room feels different because the **arrival of the baby** has changed how the narrator sees her familiar space — as though everything had quietly **made room** for a new person.

Q5. [2] — “Impossibly light... the heaviest thing I had ever held”

1 mark — **Physically**, the baby is **tiny and weighs almost nothing**.

1 mark — **Emotionally**, the **responsibility** of caring for her feels **enormous and overwhelming** — the “weight” is the weight of love, fear and lifelong duty.

Q6. [2] — Daniel’s kitchen noises

1 mark — Normally she finds his clumsiness **irritating**, suggesting they are like any ordinary couple.

1 mark — Now the noises **reassure** her because they show that **Daniel is just as nervous and unsure as she is**; they are facing the new situation **together**, and his fumbling makes her feel **less alone**.

Q7. [3] — Power of her fear (language question)

1 mark for identifying that the language conveys **overwhelming, inescapable fear**; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “a wave of fear came up through my chest” — the metaphor of a **wave** suggests the fear is **huge, sudden and uncontrollable**, like being swept under water.
- “What if I dropped her. What if I held her wrongly.” — the **repetition** of “What if” and the **full stops instead of question marks** make these fears feel like **blunt, hammering certainties**.
- “dark certainties that pressed against the inside of my ribs” — the verb **pressed** makes the fear feel **physical**, as though it is squeezing her from inside.
- “I did not phrase these thoughts as questions” — questions imply answers, so this shows her fears are **unanswerable**, making them feel even more powerful.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q8. [2] — Mother’s gesture

1 mark — She understands that her daughter **needs to hold the baby herself** / is not yet ready to share — so she **does not impose** by reaching for her grandchild.

1 mark — The **light hand on the knee** shows **quiet, wordless support** — she communicates her presence and love **without overwhelming** the new mother. (Accept: she understands intuitively, having been a new mother herself.)

Q9. [1] — Changed view of her mother

1 mark — She now **understands** her mother as a **fellow new mother** who once felt the same fear; her mother is no longer simply a parent figure but a **fellow human being** who experienced the same anxieties. (Accept: she now sees her mother with empathy / respect / recognition rather than as exaggerating.)

Q10. [1] — Fear and joy as “companions”

1 mark — She realises that, in motherhood, **fear and joy will always exist together** — that loving her child **intensely** will also mean **worrying about her constantly**, and that she must **accept both** as a permanent part of her life. (Accept: she cannot have one without the other.)

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **peaceful, accepting, reassured, calm, quietly hopeful, tender**. (Reject: **happy, triumphant** — these miss the quiet, settled quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “Belong in a museum”

1 mark — Past campaigns **urged couples to have fewer children**; the concern was **overpopulation**.

1 mark — Today this concern is so **outdated / reversed** that such posters are historical curiosities — governments now worry about **too few** children rather than too many.

Q13. [2] — “Quietly rewritten at the kitchen table”

1 mark — **Kitchen table** refers to the **private, domestic decisions** of ordinary couples (whether or not to have children).

1 mark — These **small, personal choices**, taken together, will **reshape the entire region’s future** — its economy, workforce, and society — **without any dramatic public event** (hence “quietly”).

Q14. [2] — “Indifferent to corporate convenience”

1 mark — A baby’s needs (feeding, crying, sleeping) cannot be **scheduled** around an employer’s demands.

1 mark — This **clashes** with East Asian work cultures that expect **long hours, weekend availability** and reluctance to leave the office, making it **very difficult** for working parents to manage both.

Q15. [2] — “Honest about the price they are asked to pay”

1 mark — Women are **not** avoiding motherhood out of **reluctance** / dislike of children.

1 mark — They are **clear-eyed** about the **real cost** — significant loss of earnings, slower careers, and a penalty that men do not face — and are choosing **rationally** in response.

Q16. [2] — Changes in values

1 mark each for any two of:

- Young adults **reject** the trade of long working hours for a steady salary, having watched their parents **exhaust themselves**.
- They want to **travel**, take **career risks**, and **live independently** before settling down.
- They prefer to **delay** serious commitments rather than rush into marriage and children.
- Arranged matchmaking has **declined**, so partnerships now form more slowly.

Q17. [1] — Effect of “predictable”

1 mark — It shows the writer **does not blame** young adults; the trend is a **logical, expected outcome** of broader social changes, not a moral failing. (Accept: it is **natural / inevitable** given modernisation.)

Q18. [2] — Why cash payments have failed

1 mark — Couples need **time, energy and stable careers**, not just money, to raise a child.

1 mark — Until **workplaces and the wider economy** change to support parents (e.g. shorter hours, fairer treatment of mothers), a **one-off subsidy** is far too small to outweigh the **thirty-year commitment** of raising a child.

Q19. [1] — Tone of “small consolation against a thirty-year decision”

1 mark — Any **one** of: **wry, dryly ironic, sceptical, understated, gently dismissive**. (Reject: **angry, bitter**.)

Q20. [2] — Long-run consequences

1 mark each for any two of:

- The **working-age population** will **shrink dramatically** within a generation.
- **Schools will close** and **universities will merge** (fewer young people).
- The **tax base** funding pensions and hospitals will **narrow**.
- The number of **elderly citizens needing care** will **widen**, putting pressure on health services.
- **Shortages** of essential workers (nurses, geriatric carers, even funeral directors).
- Whole **rural villages** are emptied of children, as already seen in Japan.

Q21. [2] — Effectiveness of “shared and very ordinary act of hope”

1 mark — **Shared / ordinary** reframes parenthood as a **collective, everyday** responsibility — not a **private hobby** nor a **patriotic duty** — which feels balanced and reasonable.

1 mark — **Act of hope** is **quietly powerful**: it captures the idea that having a child is a **forward-looking, trusting** decision about the future, which gives the conclusion a **humane, optimistic note** without exaggeration.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points ($\frac{1}{2}$ mark each, max 6 marks). Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.

Reasons for falling birth rates (Paragraphs 2–5):

1. **Housing** is unaffordable / flats are too small for a growing family.
2. **Work culture** demands long hours and weekend availability, leaving no room for a baby.
3. **Women** face large **career and earnings penalties** (around 30–40 per cent) after having a child; men do not.
4. Young adults hold **changing values** — they prefer to travel, take career risks, and live independently before settling down.
5. **Government cash incentives** (Baby Bonus, subsidies, cash payments) have largely **failed** because money cannot replace time, energy and career security.

Consequences of the decline (Paragraph 6):

6. The **working-age population** will **shrink sharply**, weakening the economy.
7. **Schools close** and **universities merge**; the **tax base narrows** even as the **elderly population grows**.

8. **Shortages** of nurses, carers and other essential workers appear; whole rural villages are left without children.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Birth rates in Asia are falling because housing is unaffordable, jobs demand long hours, and mothers suffer steep career and pay penalties that fathers do not. Young adults also value independence, travel and personal growth, and find that government cash incentives cannot replace lost time or career security. The consequences are severe: shrinking workforces, closing schools, narrower tax revenues, growing elderly populations, shortages of carers and nurses, and rural villages left with no children at all.

Length count: 78 words from “Birth” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —